previous two surveys. As many as 33.8 per cent said there has been no change in their income.

THE BIG DIVIDE

The perception that big businesses continue to benefit from government policies still holds sway. This belief has been further aided by the big leap that the Adani Group took in terms of its successful bid to operate several airports and the high valuation of the group's listed firms on the stock exchanges, adding to chairman Gautam Adani's wealth. Industrialist Mukesh Ambani's Reliance Industries has buttressed its position in telecom emerging as the highest bidder for 5G airwaves, and is planning a big foray into green energy. According to the 'World Inequality Report 2022' authored by Lucas Chancel, co-director of the World Inequality Lab, the top 1 per cent of India's population holds more than one-fifth of the total national income and the bottom half just 13 per cent. More than half of those surveyed in the MOTN poll felt that big businesses benefitted the most from the government's economic policies, an increase of nearly 3 percentage points from January. Only 9.5 per cent thought that small businesses gained, around 2 percentage points higher than in January.

SHORING UP THE RUPEE

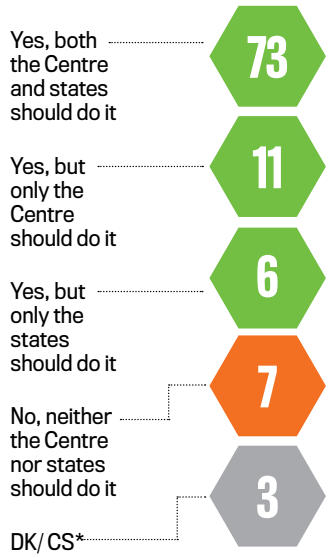
A weak currency does not necessarily mean a weak economy, but somehow there is a general tendency to think so. This was especially true when the rupee fell below the psychological mark of 80 to a dollar for the first time on July 19, on the back of the Ukraine war, high crude oil prices until a few weeks ago, and the global financial squeeze. As the RBI stepped in repeatedly to shore up the rupee, the country's forex reserves shrunk to $580 billion (around Rs 46 lakh crore) compared to $630 billion (around Rs 50 lakh crore) in February. At a macroeconomic level, a weak rupee could hurt India's economy as the current account deficit, or the difference between the value of the country's imports and exports, will widen in the process, raising the cost of overseas borrowing. The rupee has strengthened of late to 79.54 as of August 9. A whopping 64.7 per cent of respondents were worried that a falling rupee against the dollar would badly affect the economy.

High fuel prices were a matter of concern for many. In May, the Centre cut excise duty on petrol and diesel by Rs 8 and Rs 6, respectively, to tame inflation, followed by several states slashing taxes on fuel. These moves, along with the drop in Brent crude prices from over $120 a barrel in March to $96 on August 9 due to recession fears, have been of some relief to the public. However, petrol prices are still above Rs 100 per litre in several cities and towns. As many as 72.6 per cent of the respondents of the MOTN poll said that both the Centre and the states should cut duties on fuel to lower their prices.

On July 18, Sitharaman delivered yet another blow to the cryptocurrency trade when she said in the Lok Sabha that the RBI wanted to ban cryptocurrencies. With the crypto regulation bill pending in Parliament, there is confusion in the industry about whether the Centre will allow their trading, even as it bans their use as currency. The recent money-laundering allegations against WazirX, a trading platform, have added to the pessimism around cryptos. As many as 54.7 per cent of the respondents wanted the government to ban cryptocurrencies, way higher than the 38.1 per cent in January.

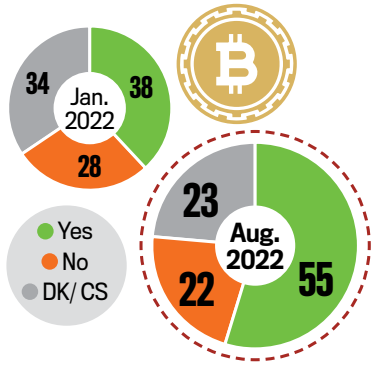
The Modi government has been able to tackle many of the challenges that have come its way, but the economy continues to be a matter of serious concern. This calls for continuing and timely interventions as the country goes through more uncertainty ahead. ■

Q. Should the Centre and the states further cut duties on fuel to bring down prices?



*Don't know/ can't say

Q. Do you want the government to ban cryptocurrencies in India?



65 PER CENT ARE WORRIED THAT A FALLING RUPEE AGAINST THE DOLLAR WILL BADLY HURT INDIAN ECONOMY

(All figures in percentage)